Further, these Americans also fundamentally grappled with social justice and creative expression, and they expanded understanding of social and political issues ranging from racial segregation and mass incarceration to U.S. militarism, immigration, gender and sexual discrimination, urban theory and social order, and historical consciousness, among other matters while in Berlin.

Artists, writers, historians, and scholars linked to Berlin have simultaneously wrestled with the complex histories of the city and Germany as a whole, especially the history and memory of fascism as it pertains to U.S. culture. In addition to exploring the Wall, they have pursued projects in Berlin that led them to engage with post-Holocaust Jewish trauma, the German student movement and other radical political collectivities, Afro-German identity, global sites of apartheid, and, eventually, German reunification in the face of a new-world, post-Soviet, order. They have also written, documented, and produced, in the creative tradition of American self-styled exile narratives, the experience of a type of curious stranger who inhabits the German American boundaries of Berlin. Gloria Anzaldúa's notion of "borderlands" is instructive here in making sense of this Cold War site within which U.S. zones of geopolitical affiliation and contact, shadowed by legacies of violence and furthered with moments of newfound solidarity, "[merge] to form a third country—a border culture."[22] U.S. dissidents, expatriates, and critical voices are drawn to contested border spaces to view the far-reaching implications of physical and social divides. Berlin's layered history has thus created a context for reflection that has functioned as a precarious and productive cultural and intellectual meeting place.

Cultural exchanges among American artists, writers, and activists who traveled to Berlin during the years of the Wall's existence yielded a wide variety of artworks, performances, texts, and new perspectives on social justice and solidarity. Collectively, the experiences of these American Berliners and their pantheon of cultural works highlight a broader cultural trope of incorporating the Wall into homegrown narratives of American freedom and repression. Across historical eras, artists and writers have continued to pursue a version of exile or exploration in Berlin as a matter of productivity and refuge. As Stuart Braun has argued, "Berlin is Berlin because of its strangers, its wanderers, its many displaced people who have come to build a kind of safe haven."[23]